

FILM REVIEWS

means, then the wrong. "Maangne se kuch nahin milta yaha, chheenna padta hai," says Raaz, the watchman who, in the ultimate cliché, needs money to send home as his son is dying of typhoid. Mathur as the waiter wants to impress a drug-peddling young Italian who is clearly pulling a fast one on him. And Shah as the driver, well, he's just had it with the rude rich bitch, his employer's wife, who treats him worse than vermin. When the apartment-wallahs refuse to lend Raaz money for his dying child, he decides to grab an opportunity that has come his way. The three are sucked into a life of crime, and there's nothing pathetic about it. It's their assertion of power, their way of getting noticed. The direction is assured. The gutters, the tiny shops, the cheek-by-jowl chawls and the inevitable railway tracks are well-photographed. And the characters are worn like second skins. Dark but deadly.

by Kaveree Bamzai

RAAZ, SHAH
AND MATHUR



A STILL FROM FIRAAQ

FIRAAQ

Fear Factor

Director: Nandita Das

Starring: Naseeruddin Shah, Shahana Goswami, Sanjay Suri

RATING ★ ★ ★ ☆ ☆

Sirf saat suron mein itni kabliyat kahan ki aisi nafrat ka samna karen. Shah is Khan Saheb, a classical musician whose students are Hindu. "When did we become we?" asks Suri, playing Sameer, a Muslim married to a Hindu. These English channels have nothing better to do than spew lies, says fundamentalist Hindu Paresh Rawal, while his wife mutilates herself with burning oil as she recalls the Muslim woman whom she could not help. The smell of burning flesh and the stench of fear is everywhere in Nandita Das' debut directorial film. A *mazaar* that no longer exists, a life packed in boxes and ready to move to Delhi, a wife who loathes the man her husband has become, a waif named Mohsin who tries to pass off as Mohan, and a mehndiwali who wears a bindi so that the pretty people she is working on don't feel threatened. No movie has shown the fear and terror felt by a community so acutely.

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ARTEXHIBITION

Cry for Harmony

The socio-political environment has a major impact on the common man's psyche. Artist Veer Munshi's show titled *Shrapnel* is an effort to depict the impact on society of the ongoing terror in Kashmir and the Mumbai attacks. Through his work Munshi expresses the violation of human rights in Kashmir.



A WORK BY MUNSHI

The show is a combination of paintings and photographs divided into two categories—The Chamber and Pandit Houses. Curated by Ranjit Hoskote, it promotes the themes of peace and secularism. The suite of 25 photographs called *Pandit Houses* presents a graphic narrative of abandoned homes of Kashmiri Pandits. He shot them over a period of three years to capture the vanishing architecture of the 5,000-year-old civilisation. "When I walked through the town and other areas I noticed many houses had been rebuilt. This represented the changing fibre of the community," says Munshi. The exhibition is also an endeavour by Foundation B&G, to promote the belief that art can and should play a constructive role in a civilised society. On display till April 4 at Tao Art Gallery, Mumbai.

by Nikita Jain